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Introduction

In recent years, social media has integrated deeply into everyday life, with individuals dedicating substantial time to engaging with diverse platforms as both consumers and content creators. This constant interaction plays a pivotal role in shaping social values, beliefs, and personal identities. Among the most influential trends to emerge from this digital environment can be considered a “hustle culture”, or a “workaholic culture associated with non-stop busyness, workload, limited time, and pressure” (Assariy, Hersari, Sitorus, Arifin, & Faisal, 2024). In the contemporary world, it has become a popular phenomenon in response to increasing economic challenges and elevated standards of living (Hasanah, Vardhani & Martha, 2024) that force people to rush and strive for success often neglecting one’s well-being. This cultural trend has been actively propagated through social media tools, particularly on YouTube as one of the most popular video sharing platforms. In video blogs, or vlogs, which constitute a primary format on YouTube, content creators employ the power of storytelling to engage their audiences and convey meaningful messages, including those centered around the ideals of constant productivity and success. Despite the popularity of the trend on the media resource, while hustle culture has been explored as a force to impact mental and physical health (Hasanah et al., 2024; Mardiana et al., 2023; Verma, 2022; Wong, Chan, & Ngan, 2019), its verbal and cultural representation in media remains underexplored (Jepsen & Eaton, 2025).

Thus, this research aims to examine and compare the linguistic and cultural features that contribute to the construction of hustle culture in American and Russian YouTube vlogs. Accordingly, the paper includes the following research questions:

1) What is the linguistic representation of hustle culture in American and Russian YouTube vlogs?

2) How are cultural dimensions represented in American and Russian vlogs about hustle culture?

In order to achieve the aim of this study, this paper will employ a mixed-methods approach to investigate the hustle culture discourse. Firstly, Norman Fairclough’s (1995) Critical Discourse Analysis will be applied to explore the linguistic

representation of hustle culture. Secondly, Hofstede's (2010) Cross-Cultural Analysis will be utilised to analyse how hustle culture portrayal in American and Russian YouTube vlogs corresponds to the cultural dimensions connected with this phenomenon. By combining these methodological approaches, the present study endeavors to offer a deeper comprehension of hustle culture across cultural settings.

Overall, this study aims to compare linguistic and cultural representation of the hustle trend in American and Russian communities. Firstly, the theoretical aspects concerning the impact of hustle culture on health as well as the description of hustle culture discourse as discussed in previous studies will be explored. Subsequently, a critical discourse analysis will be conducted on a corpus of selected 32 YouTube videos that explore the themes of hustle culture, success, and productivity, offering perspectives that both endorse and challenge these concepts. The analysis will be confined to videos that explicitly invoke the specified concepts within their titles, thereby ensuring clarity of focus and minimising any ambiguity or interference from unrelated phenomena. Drawing on the findings of the critical discourse analysis, the cross cultural analysis may provide new insights into the ways hustle culture operates within varied linguistic and cultural contexts.

Regarding the practical significance of this research, the findings are expected to enhance individuals' awareness of the linguistic mechanisms[1] employed within hustle culture, thereby enabling a more critical evaluation and resistance to its influence. Additionally, this study may contribute meaningfully to the field of intercultural communication and serve as a valuable resource in seminars and courses related to Intercultural Corporate Communication. By elucidating the processes through which cultural phenomena, namely hustle culture, are formed and sustained across various societies, the research advances a more comprehensive understanding of the interactions between language, culture, and social practices in a global context.

The work was validated in the format of a presentation at the Scientific Student Conference "The Youth in Science: Challenges and Prospects" and the X Scientific

[1] For convenience, the terms *means*, *tools* and *mechanisms* will be used interchangeably in this study.

Interuniversity Online Conference of Young Scientists “Space of scientific interests: foreign languages and intercultural communication – modern development vectors and prospects”.

As for the contribution of each author, Anastasiya Baravikowa was responsible for the discussion section, the parts connected to cultural dimensions as a student specialised in intercultural communication as well as the analysis of 8 American (vlogs 3, 5, 6, 9, 10, 11, 13, 15 in Appendices) and 8 Russian videos (vlogs 1, 3, 4, 8, 9, 10, 12, 14 in Appendices). Karina Samyltyrova prepared the methodology section and the analysis of 8 American (vlogs 1, 2, 4, 7, 8, 14, 12, 16 in Appendices) and 8 Russian videos (vlogs 2, 5, 6, 7, 11, 13, 15, 16 in Appendices). Both authors contributed equally to introduction, literature review, results, and conclusion along with searching relevant sources, data analysis, compiling appendices and editing the paper.

Literature Review

In recent years, the idea of “hustle culture” has become increasingly prominent across digital platforms, influencing societal attitudes toward work, achievement, and self-identity. This section explores various sides of hustle culture, including its definition, effects on mental and physical health, and its representation on social media. Particularly, the vlog as a media genre is considered due to the format serving as a powerful instrument for portraying and disseminating hustle ideas. An additional focus is placed on the discourse of hustle culture and the attempt to identify its main characteristics. Furthermore, culture-specific traits of hustle phenomenon are analysed through Hofstede’s cultural dimensions theory (2010) to comprehend how American and Russian cultural values shape attitudes toward work, success, and social behavior. By investigating these interrelated themes, this review seeks to deepen the understanding of hustle culture’s complexity and the influential role of vlogs together with cultural values in both reflecting and reinforcing the trend.

Hustle Culture Phenomenon

Hustle Culture: Historical Background

In order to explore the phenomenon of hustle culture, it seems essential to start with its origins. The researchers suggest that the emergence of hustle culture is linked to

the industrial revolution, which transpired in the 1970s, and marked the era of the harshest labor conditions with long hours and low wages (Balkeran, 2020; Bellini & Lomazz, 2024; Ulfah & Nurdin, 2022; Peric, 2024; Putri, 2022). The concept of "Time is Money", introduced by mechanised factory work, linked productivity directly to working hours (Putri, 2022). Corporate culture, shaped since the 1980s, began to emphasise shared values and behaviors reflected in its dress code, business hours, office setup, and employee benefits (Tarver, 2021). By the 1990s, technology firms began to dominate the market, setting a new standard that encouraged young workers to accept overwork as normal (Alp Consulting, 2023). During this time, prominent entrepreneurs actively promoted the idea of excessive working hours, framing it as a form of personal freedom and empowerment. With the rise of social media in the early 2000s, sharing personal experiences became easier, but these platforms quickly evolved into highly competitive spaces that highlight only the most successful and polished aspects of people's lives. This environment of constant comparison helped fuel the widespread influence of hustle culture, which promises a glorified lifestyle achieved through relentless hard work.

The sociological foundations of hustle culture can be linked to Max Weber's analysis of Protestant work ethics, which emphasised individual responsibility, diligence, and the pursuit of professional perfection as a moral imperative (Weber, 1905 as cited in Bellini & Lomazz, 2024). This ethic fostered an endless race for success, where work became central to personal identity and a pathway to fulfillment as devotion to God, which now seems as an alienated version of contemporary hustle culture.

While Marx's concept of "value" originally highlighted how capitalism exploited workers through long hours and low pay, this notion has transformed (Ulfah & Nurdin, 2022), the Industrial Revolution 4.0 has progressed into a new phase characterised by a stronger focus on human-centered values within the industrial landscape. This latest evolution, often referred to as Industry 5.0, sees the rise of companies whose corporate culture and values have become crucial in attracting talent, emphasising shared beliefs and behaviors. Despite these cultural shifts, fundamental expectations in the modern

work ethic remain consistent: workers are still required to exercise self-discipline, prioritise productivity, and avoid wasteful habits (Faler, 2015).

Notion of Hustle Culture

It can be seen that the understanding of the hustle phenomenon has been altered from harsh labour with long working hours in the modernist times to the corporate value of hard work and productivity in the post-modern society. It has acquired various interrelated names such as "toxic productivity" (Achmad & Lubna, 2023; Assariy et al., 2024; Hasanah et al., 2024; Perić, 2024), "rise and grind mentality" (Balkeran, 2020; Perić, 2024), "toil glamour" (Balkeran, 2020; Perić, 2024), "culture of bustle" (Assariy et al., 2024; Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023), "rush culture" (Assariy et al., 2024), and "workaholic culture" (Assariy et al., 2024; Balkeran, 2020; Hasanah et al., 2024; Kaur Arora et al., 2024; Maharani et al., 2024; Mardiana et al., 2023; Perić, 2024). Despite the common ground, the notion of hustle culture is not unified and includes a wide range of additional meanings.

First, most authors define "hustle culture" as a culture that encourages non-stop work, long working hours, refusal to rest, and a constant drive for productivity to achieve success (Assariy et al., 2024; Balkeran, 2020; Bellini & Lomazz, 2024; Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023; Hasanah et al., 2024; Mardiana et al., 2023; Perić, 2024). In this culture, work is considered to be above all health and personal life (Hasanah et al., 2024; Mardiana et al., 2023), and being successful – working hard without time constraints (Assariy et al., 2024; Hasanah et al., 2024; Perić, 2024).

Second, hustle culture can be understood as a movement that fosters motivation and is accompanied by anticipated rewards (Ulfah & Nurdin, 2022). This phenomenon, which implies individuals reducing their available time for work, is often linked to particular generations. Several studies (Achmad & Lubna, 2023; Assariy et al., 2024; Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023; Hasanah et al., 2024; Patri 2022) suggest that Millennials (1981-1996) and Generation Z (1997-2012) are the primary demographics associated with hustle culture. Internal factors such as desire for self-actualization, independence, high ambitions, and external factors, including economic instability, financial demands, changing labor markets, are assumed to intensify the pressure on younger generations to

adopt a "hustle" mindset and push them toward multiple income streams and continuous upskilling (Ulfah & Nurdin, 2022). Social media platforms play a crucial role in shaping generational attitudes toward hustle culture and amplify the pressure through hashtags, reinforcing the idea that success is achieved through constant work and effort (Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023).

Third, hustle culture can be perceived as an ideology, a system of beliefs and values concerning success, relentless work, and productivity. It is interpreted as a product of late capitalism, reviving the myths of the “American Dream” through technological optimism (Hill, 2020). Besides, capitalism together with globalisation, has affected people’s lifestyle, leading individuals toward consumerist behaviors and, in some cases, hedonism (Hennessy, 2017 as cited in Maharani et al., 2024). Hustle culture is also assumed to inherit elements of the Protestant work ethic (the value of labor) but shifts the focus from spiritual to economic goals (Hill, 2020).

Overall, hustle culture is characterised by the glorification of relentless work, productivity, and success. Formed by social, cultural, and technological forces that prioritise professional achievement over work-life balance, it is increasingly recognised as a source of workaholism and unsustainable living.

Additional attention is devoted to the investigation of how hustle culture influences individuals’ lives. Evaluating whether this phenomenon reflects a benign lifestyle choice popularised via social media or signifies significant threats to well-being is pivotal for analysing modern societal norms. Existing evidence underscores negative repercussions linked to hustle culture, including detrimental effects on both physical and mental health.

Specifically, research discovered the correlation between prolonged working hours and physiological health concerns such as digestive problems, headaches, muscle tension, cardiovascular issues, including heart disease, heart attack, high blood pressure, and stroke (Clinic Staff as cited in Perić, 2024), as well as fatigue and sleep disorders (Hasanah et al., 2024; Mardiana et al., 2023; Verma, 2022; Wong, Chan, & Ngan, 2019).

Other studies indicate negative impact of hustle culture on mental health, namely postponed life syndrome (Najdenova, 2022), imbalance between personal and professional life (Putri, 2022; Test Gorilla as cited in Perić, 2024), affecting family relationships and social interactions, poor lifestyle choices and neglect of necessary rest (Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023; Saputra, 2024), chronic stress, resulting in burnout and mental exhaustion (Balkeran, 2020; Hasanah et al., 2024) as well as anxiety, depression (Assariy et al., 2024; Hasanah et al., 2024; Kim et al., 2019; Mardiana et al., 2023; Perić, 2024), and the desire to commit suicide (Assariy et al., 2024; Perić, 2024).

Thus, hustle culture appears to evoke serious concern regarding individuals' well-being. Some researchers suggest prevention efforts to reduce work stress-induced health problems, advocating for inclusive company practices prioritising long-term success through flexible work arrangements, setting boundaries, skill development, and health support comprising psychological safety (e.g., encouraging breaks, accepting mistakes), stress management programs, and shifting focus from profit to people (Hasanah et al., 2024; Perić, 2024). However, little research is dedicated to the role of social media in influencing individuals' work habits and wellness, since most studies focus primarily on examining face-to-face interactions among employees within specific companies or organisations to assess the effects of participating in "hustle culture," often overlooking the significance of digital influence among these workers.

Discourse of Hustle Culture

Definition of Discourse

In order to examine the linguistic and cultural representation of the hustle trend, it seems necessary to analyse the discourse surrounding this phenomenon. Discourse, as a notion in general, serves as a foundational framework for interdisciplinary research that integrates insights from linguistics, sociology, psychology, political science, and cultural studies. It functions as a critical lens through which social phenomena, such as power relations, identity construction, and ideological formations, are examined across diverse contexts and modes of communication (Muxtorova & Abdullaeva, 2024). This broad applicability has given rise to Discourse Studies as a transdisciplinary field, characterised by its theoretical orientations and

methodological tools that explore the interplay between language and society, particularly focusing on how discourse shapes and is shaped by social structures and power dynamics.

In Discourse Studies, “discourse” is generally understood as a social practice whereby participants engage in communication using linguistic and other semiotic resources within specific contexts (Angermuller, Maingueneau, & Wodak, 2014). The scholars emphasise the constitutive nature of discourse, which can be divided into two approaches: one that treats discourse as an intellectual and epistemological issue central to social, political, and cultural theory, which can be referred as “discourse theory”, and another that addresses the analytical and methodological processes involved in examining discourse as a tangible and empirical phenomenon, or, in other words, “discourse analysis”.

In particular, discourse theory encompasses three main approaches: post-structuralist, normative-deliberative, and critical-realist. First, post-structuralist theory highlights the constitutive role of language in shaping social reality, viewing discourse as constructing social structures and power relations. Influenced by Foucault (2013) and Pêcheux (1975), this perspective focuses on the contingent character of knowledge and identity. Second, normative-deliberative theory sees discourse as a means of negotiating agreements among participants to resolve conflicts in the public sphere, promoting free deliberation and rational consensus. While strong versions, exemplified by Habermas, assert that communicative processes are governed by inherent rational norms and universal principles that enable participants to reach consensus through reasoned argumentation (1985), weaker versions challenge this universalism (Lyoutard, 1994). Third, critical-realist theory considers discourse a social practice embedded in power structures, producing and reproducing inequalities between social groups. Influenced by critical realism, linguists have integrated its philosophical principles into Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) to deepen the examination of social issues through language. This approach, notably advanced by Norman Fairclough, treats discourse not merely as text or talk but as a social practice embedded within real-world power structures and material conditions (1995).

Thus, these strands share a focus on language, communication, and meaning in social theory but differ in their approaches to power, knowledge, and subjectivity. Post-structuralism decenters identities, normative-deliberative theory highlights tensions between ideal and actual discourse, and critical realism reveals power structures hidden beneath representations. Together, these theories demonstrate how discourse shapes and is shaped by power, knowledge, and the construction of subjectivity.

Definition of Hustle Culture Discourse

Although hustle culture has gained widespread global popularity, its discourse remains largely undescribed in academic literature. In order to address this gap, the terminology and methodological framework proposed by Norman Fairclough (1995), whose critical discourse analysis (CDA) approach has been applied in this study, was adopted. Fairclough's framework conceptualises discourse as both socially shaped and socially constitutive, meaning that language use reflects existing social conventions while also having the potential to transform social relations and identities (Fairclough, 1995, p. 131). Applying this to hustle culture, Hustle Culture Discourse can be defined as a socially constructed and socially influential way of representing and communicating the values, behaviors, and ideologies associated with relentless, excessive work, and constant productivity. Thus, the discourse of hustle culture not only mirrors prevailing societal norms about work ethic and success but also actively shapes individuals' perceptions and practices related to labor and achievement.

Drawing on various discourse classification systems (See Table 1), Hustle Culture Discourse can be understood as encompassing multiple interconnected discourse types, each contributing to its overall communicative function and social impact.

Table 1

Classifications of Discourse

Discourse types	Author
narration, exposition, description,	(Bain, 1890)

argumentation	
transactional, expressive, poetic	(Britton, J., Burgess, T., Martin, N., McLeod, A., & Rosen, 1975)
expressive, referential, persuasive, literary	(Kinneavy, 1980)
narration, procedural, behavioral, expository	(Longacre, 1996)
personal, institutional	(Karasik, 2002)
monologic, dialogic	(Bakhtin, 2010)

Primarily, it functions as an argumentation discourse, where claims about the value and necessity of relentless work and productivity are put forward and justified. This argumentative dimension constructs a rationale that frames hustle culture as essential for success and self-worth in contemporary society.

Furthermore, Hustle Culture Discourse operates as persuasive discourse, aiming to influence and motivate audiences to adopt the values and behaviors associated with constant productivity and overwork. Through motivational language, success stories, and social validation, this discourse encourages individuals to internalize the hustle ethos as a desirable lifestyle choice.

In addition, it can be classified as transactional discourse because it involves exchanges of expectations and commitments between various social roles, such as employers, employees, influencers, and followers. These interactions often implicitly or explicitly set standards for work ethic and dedication, shaping workplace norms and individual behaviors. The transactional nature is evident in the unspoken agreements within organisations that equate employee worth with visible commitment and productivity, reinforcing hustle culture as a baseline expectation.

Moreover, Hustle Culture Discourse embodies behavioral discourse, as it not only promotes particular values but also prescribes specific actions and habits. It encourages individuals to engage in continuous work, sacrifice leisure time, and prioritize career advancement, effectively shaping everyday practices and lifestyle choices. This behavioral aspect is reinforced through social media narratives that romanticise exhaustion and glorify workaholism as a symbol of pride.

Beyond these types, Hustle Culture Discourse can be attributed to an institutional discourse, reflecting and reinforcing the norms, values, and role expectations imposed by powerful social institutions, especially media and mass culture. These institutions disseminate and legitimise the hustle ideology by promoting narratives that equate success with unceasing productivity and self-sacrifice. Media platforms, particularly social media, play a pivotal role in normalising hustle culture by showcasing curated success stories and productivity performances, often glossing over the detrimental effects on well-being. Besides, institutional discourse functions to maintain and reproduce social order by embedding these values within organisational cultures and societal expectations. For example, workplace communication often perpetuates hustle culture norms through implicit demands for constant productivity and exceptional dedication, which become internalised by employees as professional standards.

Finally, Hustle Culture Discourse can be fruitfully analysed as a form of dialogic discourse in the sense that it carries two semantic intentions simultaneously: the voice promoting hustle culture ideals and the implicit or explicit response to critiques or alternative viewpoints. For instance, motivational posts on social media may adopt a tone that simultaneously endorses the hustle ethos while subtly responding to societal concerns about burnout or work-life balance. Based on Bakhtin’s theoretical framework (2010), Hustle Culture Discourse can be called polyphonic, meaning it involves a coexistence and interaction of diverse voices and attitudes toward work, productivity, and success. For example, within this discourse, while some people glorify relentless effort and constant productivity, framing them as moral imperatives, there are counter-voices, often emerging from mental health advocates, critics of overwork, or alternative lifestyle proponents that challenge the sustainability and ethics of such a lifestyle. Thus,

this form can enrich the discourse, making it a site of negotiation rather than a fixed, authoritative narrative.

According to Hill (2020), hustle culture relies on three main principles, which constitute the core of its discourse: entrepreneurialism, psychological and digital tools. First, hustle culture promotes the belief that entrepreneurial qualities such as grit, hard work, persistence, optimism, and market savvy are essential for modern success. This mindset is reflected in popular slogans and the idea that anyone can approach life with the drive of a CEO. Second, adherents of hustle culture emphasise the importance of a positive, growth-oriented mindset, believing that overcoming a "limited mindset" is crucial to success, and so they adopt various productivity hacks, routines, and self-improvement tactics. This focus on mindset often leads to reframing structural barriers as personal challenges to be overcome by attitude and effort, offering a sense of empowerment even in the face of inequality. Third, technology platforms provide opportunities to monetise skills, products, services or even personality to achieve financial freedom.

With regard to the foregoing, Hustle Culture Discourse has a complex, multi-layered nature that prescribes behaviors linked to relentless productivity, empowerment, and success. Its institutional and dialogical form underscores the powerful role of media and organisational structures in shaping and sustaining this discourse, making it a pervasive and influential force in contemporary social life.

Hustle Culture Discourse in Social Media

The trend of hustle culture has become increasingly popular in modern society, promoting nonstop productivity and ambition that is actively reinforced by the impact of social media. In fact, it is distributed through various hashtags that are commonly used to tag and search for hustle culture-related content on social media, for instance, "#riseandgrind" (Assariy et al., 2024; Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023; Griffith as cited in Absher, 2020), "#hustle" (Assariy et al., 2024; Griffith as cited in Absher, 2020), "#grindtime" (Assariy et al., 2024), "#cantstopwontstop" (Griffith as cited in Absher, 2020), #ThankGodItsMonday, #NoDaysOff or #EverydayImHustling (Perić, 2024).

Social media platforms such as Instagram*[2], Twitter*[3], and TikTok*[4] amplify the hustle culture trend through visually appealing content that normalises overwork. For example, there have been identified four common types of content observed in posts related to hustle culture on social media: 1) “the hustle bustle”, which is depictions of constant productivity measured by multitasking and long hours; 2) “achievements and income”, posts showcasing salaries or professional milestones; 3) “lifestyle”, represented by trends “a day in my life”, glamorising urban work environments; and 4) motivational content with inspirational quotes and success stories that equate self-worth with productivity (Chairunnisah & Kurnia, 2023).

Besides, hustle culture popularises slogans and motivational phrases. A study examined motivational hustle culture quotes combining text and imagery to construct meaning, using Multimodal Discourse Analysis (MDA) (Christina & Shasita, 2022). The findings showed that, within 30 motivational quotes, declarative and imperative clauses were used at the textual level as well as metaphorical imagery, literal imagery, tones, and techniques as visual elements to reinforce the hustle trend. Some other examples of quotes in another work suggest that one can approach all aspects of life with the same dedication and resilience as a CEO to maximise success: “Be the CEO of your life.”; “It’s not about money or connections. It’s the willingness to outwork and outlearn everyone when it comes to your business.”; “I’d rather hustle 24/7 than slave 9 to 5.” (Hill, 2020, p. 9).

Despite previous research focusing on hustle culture’s presence in social media posts and motivational quotes, the trend remains underexplored in video formats, particularly in YouTube vlogs. Exploring hustle culture through YouTube vlogs could deepen the understanding of how this discourse shapes identities and social expectations not only in static posts or quotes, but also in a more dynamic and interactive type of content.

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[2] *Meta**, including its products *Instagram** and *Facebook**, are recognised as an extremist organisation in Russia.

[3] Roskomnadzor blocked *Twitter* in early March 2022 by the decision of the Prosecutor General’s Office dated February 24, 2022 on the basis of Article 15.3 of the law on Information, Information Technologies, and Information Protection.

[4] On March 6, 2022, *Tik Tok* suspended its operations in Russia due to new amendments to Russian legislation.

Hustle Culture and Vlogs

Although research has focused on hustle culture short multimedia content, there is a growing recognition that longer narratives about hustle culture are better suited to video-sharing platforms, most notably YouTube (Holland, 2016). YouTube stands out as one of the most popular platforms for both uploading and consuming extended video content, providing a space where creators can delve deeper into their experiences and perspectives.

A central format on YouTube is the vlog, or video blog, which merges ongoing storytelling with rich audio-visual elements to engage viewers in a more immersive way (Kim, 2017, p. 7). Vlogs serve multiple important functions, including self-expression, self-presentation, role modeling, and even advertisement, making them powerful tools for shaping public perceptions and influencing audiences (Maden & Kalafatoğlu, 2022). While Maden and Kalafatoğlu emphasise how vloggers build and influence communities through parasocial or one-sided connections where viewers feel personally connected to creators, Werner (2012) highlights that vlogging can function both as a monologue and as a dynamic dialogue between creators and their audiences.

This interactive dimension is a defining characteristic of vlogs, alongside their intimate tone, relatively short duration, and asynchronous format, which allows viewers to engage with content on their own time. Such interactivity is particularly significant in shaping how viewers perceive and internalize hustle culture, as it enables creators to respond to comments and feedback, fostering a sense of belonging and community among followers. This ongoing exchange strengthens viewer loyalty and trust, which are essential for effective communication and influence.

Werner (2012) further describes vlogging as a potent rhetorical practice distinguished by its conversational style, emotional expressiveness, and capacity to disseminate information of public interest while providing immediate opportunities for public expression. Despite the comprehensive vlog typologies proposed by scholars like Gercely (2018) (as cited in Maden & Kalafatoğlu, 2022), motivational vlogs remain underrecognised as a distinct genre. These motivational vlogs are particularly important due to its aim to inspire and encourage viewers to take proactive steps toward achieving

their personal and professional ambitions, aligning closely with the motivational content described by Chairunnisah and Kurnia (2023) (p. 188).

Given that motivational vlogs on YouTube have not yet been thoroughly studied as a medium for the dissemination and popularisation of hustle culture, this research seeks to explore how motivational vloggers use linguistic elements to construct narratives around hustle culture. As vlogs offer a unique blend of storytelling, emotional connection, and interactivity, it can deeply influence viewers' values, attitudes, and behaviors related to work ethic, ambition, and self-identity in the digital era.

Understanding Cultural Dimensions

With the aim of deeply analysing cross-cultural differences and peculiarities of perception of various social phenomena, researchers often appeal to the theories of cultural dimensions. These models allow structuring and quantifying differences between cultures based on their values, attitudes, and behaviours. First and foremost, Gert Hofstede's model of cultural dimensions, which is one of the most well-known and widely used models, is grounded on the investigation of variations in values within different sectors of IBM, a global computer manufacturing company (Hofstede, 1980). The framework was further expanded and refined to encompass six dimensions, namely Masculinity/Femininity, Individualism/Collectivism, Short-/Long-Term Orientation, Power Distance, Uncertainty Avoidance, and Indulgence (Hofstede et al., 2010). It is pointed out that each of the dimensions illustrates the value system intrinsic to a culture and, therefore, they have the potential to be used to predict people's behaviour in professional and everyday environments (Hofstede, 2011).

Although Hofstede's model is widely used and reasonably popular, it is not entirely unique. Another imperative theoretical framework worth mentioning is the approach of Fons Trompenaars and Charles Hampden-Turner, who distinguished seven cultural dimensions: Universalism vs. Particularism, Individualism vs. Communitarianism, Neutral vs. Emotional, Specific vs. Diffuse, Achievement vs. Ascription, Attitudes to Time, and Attitudes to the Environment (Trompenaars & Hampden-Turner, 1997). Unlike Hofstede, they concentrated on solving cultural

dilemmas, i.e. how people choose between opposing behavioural strategies in different situations.

Another significant contribution to the study of cultural differences was a study by Ronald Inglehart and Christopher Welzel, based on data from the World Values Survey (Inglehart & Welzel, 2005). They identified two main axes of cultural change: Traditional vs. Secular-Rational values and Survival vs. Self-Expression values. The authors present a model of social change that predicts how value systems are likely to evolve in the coming decades under conditions of economic development and democratisation.

It is noteworthy that these models are actively utilised in media and communication studies. For instance, cultural dimensions have been applied to analyse the content of advertising, political discourse, and video content on social media. For example, Guftométros and Guerreiro (2021) employ Hofstede's model to identify cultural differences in Facebook* user behaviour, such as the propensity to like, comment and repost, in order to predict consumers' online reactions in different countries.

In the context of YouTube, Hofstede's framework has also found application. For example, a study by Park et al. (2017) demonstrated that countries' cultural values influence the consumption of popular YouTube videos and limit cultural convergence despite global access to content. Besides, in the research by Choi (2021), this framework was used to compare cultural values reflected in popular YouTube commercials in the United States and South Korea, which helped to reveal that unlike traditional advertising, online video advertising is less reflective of cultural differences and more focused on individual and emotional characteristics.

Hence, cultural measurement theories provide powerful tools for comparative analysis, especially in the context of digital globalisation, when media content becomes accessible to representatives of different cultures. Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory (2010) was chosen in this study owing to its clarity, broad applicability in cross-cultural research, and the possibility of a specific numerical expression of the characteristics of cultures, which is convenient when analysing YouTube video content.

Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Framework

YouTube's global platform brings together a culturally diverse audience, making it possible to examine how cultural values might shape the interpretation of hustle culture as portrayed in motivational vlogs. The way viewers perceive and respond to the ethos of constant productivity and success may vary significantly depending on their cultural backgrounds. . Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory (2010) is employed as a guiding framework in this study in order to systematically investigate these differences. This theory identifies six key dimensions that can be used to describe and distinguish cultures: Masculinity/Femininity, Individualism/Collectivism, Short-/Long-Term Orientation, Power Distance, Uncertainty Avoidance, and Indulgence (see Table 2).

Table 2

Hofstede's Cultural Dimensions Theory (Hofstede et al., 2010)

Dimension	Explanation
Masculinity/ Femininity	Masculinity is associated with traits such as competitiveness, ambition, and assertiveness, often driving a focus on material accomplishments and status. Femininity, instead, underscores the importance of cooperation, empathy, and overall well-being, emphasising harmony and strong interpersonal connections.
Individualism/ Collectivism	Individualism centers on personal independence and self-definition, placing individual achievements and aspirations above those of the group. In contrast, collectivism highlights the importance of group affiliation and shared objectives, often prioritising the needs and interests of the group over those of the individual.

Power Distance	Power Distance refers to the degree to which individuals in a society accept and expect unequal distribution of power among its members. A high Power Distance Index (PDI) reflects a society's acceptance of established hierarchies and authority, whereas a low PDI indicates a stronger preference for egalitarian relationships and equal power sharing.
Short-/Long-Term Orientation	Short-term orientation prioritises immediate outcomes and quick results, while Long-Term Orientation reflects a society's emphasis on future planning and perseverance.
Uncertainty Avoidance	Uncertainty avoidance refers to the degree to which people within a culture experience discomfort or anxiety when faced with ambiguous or unfamiliar circumstances. This unease often manifests as stress and a strong desire for predictability, which is typically addressed through the establishment and adherence to formal and informal rules.
Indulgence/ Restraint	Indulgence refers to the inclination to freely satisfy fundamental human desires associated with pleasure and enjoyment of life, whereas Restraint represents the belief that these desires should be controlled and limited by rigid social rules.

Based on the definition of hustle culture and the dimensions described above, it seems reasonable to consider three of the six cultural dimensions due to their close relation to the hustle trend:

1) Masculinity/Femininity dimension contrasts societies valuing competition and material success (masculinity) with those prioritising quality of life and harmony (femininity).

2) Individualism/Collectivism dimension distinguishes societies prioritising personal success (individualism) from those valuing social achievements (collectivism).

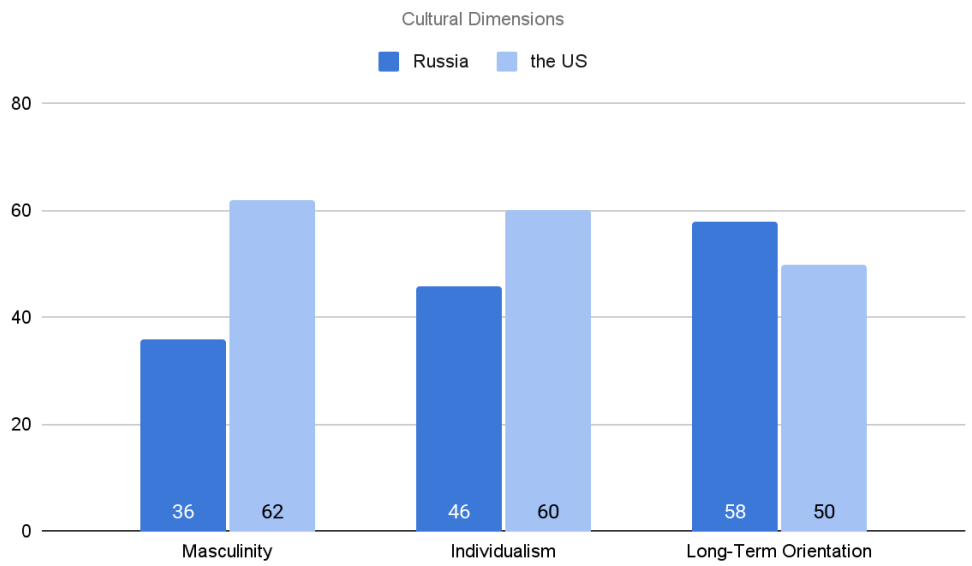
3) Short-/Long-Term Orientation dimension represents immediate results along with sustained, future-focused planning.

In accordance with these characteristics, hustle culture demonstrates a strong alignment with masculine values, as evidenced by its emphasis on ambition and material gain, often resulting in work-life imbalance. Furthermore, it is closely associated with an individualistic orientation, wherein personal achievement is regarded as a primary indicator of self-worth. Additionally, hustle culture frequently reflects a short-term orientation, focusing on rapid and visible accomplishments over sustained, long-term progress.

From the perspective of Hofstede's cultural dimensions, American and Russian cultures show notable contrasts in the dimensions of Masculinity/Femininity, Individualism/Collectivism, and Short-/Long-Term Orientation (see Figure 1).

Figure 1

Comparison of dimensions for American and Russian cultures (Country Comparison Tool, 2023)



As seen from the bar chart, The United States scores relatively high on masculinity (62), reflecting a culture that values competitiveness, achievement, and assertiveness. This translates into a strong emphasis on career success, ambition, and material rewards. In contrast, Russia scores lower on masculinity (36), indicating a culture that is less focused on competition rather than oriented toward cooperation and quality of life, meaning that Russian society tends to emphasise social cohesion and interpersonal relationships.

The US is also an individualistic society (60), with a strong focus on personal autonomy, self-expression, and individual achievement. Americans prioritise individual goals over group interests and value independence highly. Russia, however, is much more collectivist, a legacy of its Soviet past, where group loyalty, social conformity, and collective well-being are highly valuable. Russians tend to place greater importance on group norms and social harmony, often subordinating personal desires to the needs of the community or family.

Finally, both cultures show some pragmatism in balancing future planning with present needs, nevertheless, Russia exhibits a slightly stronger long-term oriented perspective. Russian culture tends to focus on foresight, perseverance, and preparing for future uncertainties, reflecting a cautious approach to change and a preference for stability. The US, while capable of long-term planning, may apply a more short-term orientation, focusing on quick results, immediate benefits, and responsiveness to current opportunities.

In view of the above, this study seeks to expand existing research by analysing the hustle culture representation in American and Russian YouTube vlogs, with a particular focus on how the language reflects the phenomenon and the cultural dimensions considered. Hustle culture, widely promoted through social media platforms, encourages audiences to pursue productivity and success; however, it presents potential health risks, such as burnout, stress, and depression. Therefore, it seems necessary to critically examine the specific language that glorifies relentless work and achievement. This research will pay special attention to how hustle culture values are portrayed by American and Russian YouTube vloggers, exploring the cultural

nuances that might influence their audiences' reception and adoption of this popular trend.

Methodology

Data Collection

For the aim of this research, a purposive sampling method was applied with a systematic set of criteria to ensure the relevance of the selected videos. The selection criteria included the language of the video, the keywords, the publication date, the length of the video, the popularity of the channel as well as the number of views and likes.

Firstly, vlogs centered on hustle culture in the American and Russian languages were selected for their pronounced prominence on the YouTube platform compared to the relevant content in other languages (i.e. French and German vlogs, initially prioritised for the study, proved scarce, with few aligning fully with the established criteria). Additionally, selecting the American and Russian languages served to facilitate the transcription[5] and analysis processes. Secondly, the video search by keywords *hustle culture*, *success*, *productivity*, the terms identified as interconnected in the literature review, guaranteed that the chosen American vlogs corresponded closely with the motivational vlog genre and the theme of hustle culture. However, only a limited number of Russian-language vlogs featured the translated versions of the corresponding terms – "культура достигаторства" ("hustle culture") and "успех" ("success") – in their titles. Consequently, the selection process shifted to prioritise videos containing the keywords "продуктивность" ("productivity") and "продуктивный" ("productive") as these more accurately reflected the core themes of the phenomenon within the Russian YouTube community. This adjustment ensured the inclusion of relevant content that aligns with the study's focus on the linguistic and cultural manifestations of hustle culture. Thirdly, the study focused on videos published within the past five years, with a duration not exceeding 25 minutes, accumulating

[5] AI tools, including *NoteGPT* and *YouTubeToTranscript*, were used to transcribe videos into text, and *ChatGPT* and *DeepSeek* were used to add punctuation marks.

either at least 100,000 views or 10,000 likes, or created by vloggers boasting at least 10,000 subscribers. This deliberate approach ensured the incorporation of material from influential channels, thereby enriching the study with content that is both impactful and representative of the phenomenon.

To ensure a diverse range of perspectives, the study selected 32 videos — 16 American and 16 Russian — that met the aforementioned criteria. The transcriptions of the selected videos have been systematically compiled in the Appendices.

Data Analysis

The data analysis commenced with the transcription of the selected YouTube vlogs to compile accurate textual records of the speakers' monologues. The transcripts were carefully reviewed and subjected to a coding process, wherein linguistic choices related to hustle culture were identified and categorised.

Following transcription, a two-step analysis was implemented. The first step consisted of Critical Discourse Analysis based on Fairclough's three-dimensional framework (1995) to systematically explore discourse at multiple levels. The analysis of each level with the corresponding examples is provided in tables 1 and 2 for American and Russian videos respectively.

The first level, textual analysis, concentrated on the micro-level linguistic features present within the vlog transcripts. This phase entailed an examination of vocabulary choices, grammatical constructions, and syntactic patterns to uncover how language was utilised to construct and convey messages associated with hustle culture. Particular attention was paid to identifying lexical fields, metaphorical language, modality, and other stylistic devices that contributed to framing success, productivity, and work ethic within the discourse.

The second level, discursive analysis, extended the investigation beyond the text itself to encompass the processes involved in the production, distribution, and reception of the vlog content. This stage examined how vlog creators crafted their messages, the platforms and channels through which these messages were disseminated, and how audiences might engage with and interpret the content. By situating each vlog within the broader discursive field of motivational and productivity-oriented media, this analysis

illuminated the intertextual relationships and positioning strategies vloggers employed to align their narratives with or differentiate them from prevailing trends in hustle culture discourse.

The third level, social practice analysis, positioned the vlogs within their broader socio-cultural context. This involved interpreting how the discourse surrounding hustle culture in American and Russian vlogs both reflected and influenced dominant societal values, norms, and ideological frameworks. The analysis explored whether and how these vlogs reinforced traditional cultural narratives about work ethic and success. It also provided critical insights into the role of discourse as a social practice that not only mirrors but also actively shapes cultural understandings related to hustle culture in diverse linguistic and cultural settings.

Based on the findings of the Critical Discourse Analysis, the study incorporated Cross-Cultural Analysis applying Hofstede's framework (2010) to reveal how American and Russian vloggers interpret hustle culture through three cultural dimensions – Masculinity/Femininity, Individualism/Collectivism, and Short-/Long-Term Orientation. This methodological choice, outlined in the literature review, was guided by the dimensions' conceptual relevance to the core themes of hustle culture, including work ethic, personal gain, and temporal orientations toward success.

By analysing representations of American and Russian cultures in vlogs through Hofstede's cultural dimensions framework, this study seeks to compare the classifications established by Hofstede with their actual manifestations in media discourse. Furthermore, the research aims to determine the extent to which each community exhibits an orientation toward hustle culture, thereby assessing the alignment between theoretical cultural profiles and contemporary media portrayals.

Overall, given the broad and complex nature of the analysis, this study could not encompass all videos related to the hustle culture phenomenon. However, the selected sample of 32 videos may provide a representative overview, establishing a basis for more detailed future investigations. Moreover, the limitations could be mitigated in subsequent research by expanding the scope to include a wider variety of platforms and languages. Despite these constraints, the present study offers valuable perspectives into

the representation of the hustle culture phenomenon within the context of media discourse. By combining critical discourse analysis and cross-cultural analysis, the study aims to identify linguistic patterns and cultural values that shape the representation of hustle culture within the digital community.

Results and Discussion

At the end of the data collection, 32 videos, 16 American and 16 Russian videos were transcribed and analysed. The American vlogs comprised a total of 38,925 words, while the Russian vlogs contained 24,579 words, resulting in an aggregate word count of 63,504. The cumulative duration of the American vlogs was 3 hours, 15 minutes, and 39 seconds, the Russian vlogs totaled 2 hours, 58 minutes, and 53 seconds, amounting to an overall duration of 6 hours, 14 minutes, and 32 seconds.

First and foremost, a Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) was conducted following Fairclough's three-dimensional model, comprising textual, discursive, and social practice analyses. After that, a Cross-Cultural Analysis utilising Hofstede's cultural dimensions helped interpret how each culture's values shape the representation of hustle culture in American and Russian vlogs. As a result, tables for Critical Discourse Analysis of American and Russian vlogs were compiled (see Appendix C, Tables C1 and C2), as well as a table for Cross-Cultural Analysis (see Appendix C, Table C3). These tables illustrate linguistic means, features of discourse and social practice levels and their examples encountered in the vlogs, which are to be analysed below.

American Vlogs

Text level

According to Table C1 (see Appendix C), the linguistic representation of hustle culture in American vlogs is characterised by a strong emphasis on personal agency, urgency, and self-optimisation. At the morphemic level, modals and quasi-modals (Collins, 2009) such as *"can"* (217), *"would"* (55), *"could"* (46), *"might"* (41), *"should"* (24), *"have to"* (74), and *"need to"* (49) are frequently employed, constructing a discourse of obligation and personal responsibility. For instance, statements such as *"You <u>need to</u> create a non-negotiable routine for yourself"*

(LenaLifts, 2024) or *"You must time each of your tasks"* (Tam Kaur, 2023) present productivity as a personal moral imperative.

Besides, the frequent use of imperatives is vivid in videos, e.g. "*Organize your life in a way that you can maximize your time"* (mikayla mags, 2025), *"Structure your day effectively"* (Sophie DiLoreto, 2024), "*For right now, just focus on the task at hand" (Helaine Zhao, 2024), "Stop thinking that you are a lazy person or a procrastinator and switch that mindset around"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024). Imperative verbs could be used to enhance the perception of self-discipline and efficiency. This may therefore reflect high masculinity, which values competitiveness and achievement, and individualism, which implies that people should be self-reliant.

Pronoun usage also highlights some peculiarities. American content creators heavily rely on personal pronouns like *"you"* and *"I"*, highlighting personal accountability, as in *"You can choose today to reinvent yourself and make 2024 your year"* (Leyla Tavas, 2023), *"I graduated from University…, and I graduated with a first-class degree…I got straight A's in my exams… I'm a full-time content creator. …I run my own business"* (Tam Kaur, 2023), *"You're going to decide for yourself right now that you are done with this"* (LenaLifts, 2024) or *"… it is about you and exactly how you can stop wasting the amazing life planned for you and make all your dreams a reality"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024); *"And, you know, I'm gonna live my life in a way that matters to me"* (Mayuko, 2021). It can be inferred that this linguistic choice enhances the idea that success or failure is an individual responsibility, which is consistent with the individualistic nature of American society.

At the textual level within CDA, lexical choices further illustrate the ideological framing of hustle culture in American vlogs (see Table 3).

Table 3

The most frequent nouns utilised to describe hustle culture in American vlogs

Nouns	Frequency
time	141

work	87
routine	79
productivity	58
goal	54
feeling	35

From this it can be inferred that the lexical choices of American vloggers indicate a strong action orientation and self-optimisation. The frequent use of *"time"* and *"productivity"* reflects the attitude of self-optimisation and the constant use of every moment to one's advantage, which is a feature of a masculine culture that values success, achievement, and results. *"Time", "goal",* and *"work"* emphasise in most vlogs that working is the meaning of life, which correlates with high individualism, namely personal responsibility and career success are equated with the value of the individual. *"Routine"* is typically associated with a long-term orientation in the sense of building structure and discipline for sustainable growth and future success. However, in American vlogs it is often presented in a way that makes it seem short-term, e.g. *"Now you know my go-to <u>routine</u> for feeling balanced and productive on my days off, but maybe you want to learn about the micro habits that set me up for success even with a busy schedule"* (Dr Faye Bate, 2025); "*Maybe in those 30 minutes, I could be editing, I could be crossing things off my to-do list, I could be doing my morning <u>routine</u>"* (mikayla mags, 2025). Finally, *"feeling"* demonstrates a strong affective involvement in the processes of productivity and self-improvement. In the context of hustle culture, emotions become an integral part of it and a criterion of success, which could emphasise the features of a masculine attitude, where feeling becomes part of the toolkit for achieving goals (e.g. emotional control).

When describing the attitude towards hustle culture, the majority of American vloggers have a tendency to employ adjectives[6], which carry a positive evaluation such as *"productive", "motivated", "positive", "happy", "perfect",* contributing to the desire of becoming like the person being described. The content creators use them to praise the idea behind the phenomenon of hustle culture and what it stands for. Adjectives *"busy"* and *"disciplined"* might be regarded as neutral. These adjectives and the frequency with which they are used are presented in Table 4.

Table 4

The most frequent adjectives utilised to describe hustle culture in American vlogs

Adjectives	Frequency
productive	87
busy	26
motivated	15
positive	13
happy	12
perfect	11
focused	9
disciplined	9

The table depicts that adjectives indicate a strong emotional orientation, ambition and self-improvement, which implies that productivity leads to the fact that one should feel *"happy"*, and *"perfect"*. As a result, this may point out a high level of

[6] *In this study, adjectives are understood as anything that is utilised as an attribute to characterise the attitude toward hustle culture. Past participle is also considered an adjective. Fairclough identifies a separate category of 'participial adjectives', e.g. required, allowed, etc. (Fairclough, 2003), however, other studies based on Fairclough's three-dimensional framework treat this category as 'adjectives' (Abcha, 2016; Ånmark, 2015; Isbuga-Erel, 2008).*

individualism and masculinity in American society, where personal success and the expression of individual feelings are valued.

The frequent use of verbs like *"feel", "work", "change", and "optimize"* in American videos reflects emotional labour and relentless self-improvement (see Table 5). The verb *"feel"* links productivity to affective states, representing success as an inner psychological achievement, whereas *"work"* reinforces the moral imperative of continuous effort. Such verbs as *"change"* and *"optimize"* point out the expectation of perpetual improvement of oneself.

Table 5

The most frequent verbs utilised to describe hustle culture in American vlogs

American verbs	Frequency
feel	179
work	48
change	15
optimize	11

These verbs shape hustle culture in American vlogs as an individualistic, highlighting results-oriented ideology that prioritises personal agency, measurable results and emotional control, which is in line with Hofstede's dimensions of high individualism and masculinity.

American vloggers often describe hustle culture through metaphors of mechanisation, pressure, and optimisation, reflecting the general idea that efficiency and results are focal. For instance, *"accelerate your productivity and unlock your creative side"* (LenaLifts, 2023); *"optimize the chunks of time"* (sarah pan, 2024); *"maximize your productivity"* (Tam Kaur, 2023). At the same time, some American content creators illustrate hustle culture from a negative perspective by turning oneself into a *"work machine"*, e.g. "*I feel like part of hustle culture is to make yourself some sort of*

work machine"; *"...this position just feels very counterculture to hustle culture, where a lot of it is about maxing ourselves out like machines"* (Mayuko, 2021).

Similarly, metaphors such as *"brain dump"*, *"mental load"*, and *"cluttered brain"* (Dr Faye Bate, 2025; Sophie DiLoreto, 2024) represent the self as a data processor that must be periodically cleared to remain functional. Even positive routines are reframed as tools for performance optimisation, e.g. *"diamonds are made under pressure"* (Anna Neubert, 2025), which implies that stress and hustle are productive by nature. As a consequence, these metaphorical framings indicate a high Masculinity stressing productivity, ambition and competitiveness, as well as a strong Individualism where personal autonomy and responsibility dominate the narrative. Furthermore, the focus on life hacks to save time and instant productivity is observable, e.g. *"Even though cleaning dishes won't take you more than 30 minutes, it's still unloading a lot of mental load"* (sarah pan, 2024), is consistent with a Short-Term Orientation, favouring immediate results over gradual development.

The following frequently repeated metaphors that have come to be used as slang are *"get out of the lazy rut"* and *"enter "that girl" era"* (Leyla Tavas, 2023; Tam Kaur, 2023). Both metaphors reflect core aspects of hustle culture, namely that unproductivity is a disease or a trap to eliminate, whereas development is a transformation of the individual, as if one can 'enter' a new way of life. Notwithstanding the fact that the image of 'that girl' is feminine in appearance but metaphorically linked to masculine values such as determination, productivity, and inner toughness.

One more peculiar linguistic means that is bound to be regarded in the research is personification. In American videos, hustle culture itself is personified as a powerful external force: "*<u>It</u> [hustle culture] <u>promises</u> this sort of utopia that we're, I guess, trying to reach, in which our whole self is defined by the work we do"* (Mayuko, 2021); and the "*<u>life</u> you want*" is depicted as something that "*<u>requires to put</u> in work and make sacrifices*" (LenaLifts, 2024). These constructions depict goals as demanding entities that the subject must serve, reinforcing a vision of externalised discipline and self-sacrifice for the sake of the desired life.

Furthermore, in the American vlogs, repetition emerges as an affirmative strategy. Lexical units such as "*productive*", "*mindset*", and "*maximize*" are not merely repeated for emphasis, they serve to instil that people must strive for success and constantly develop, as required by the hustle culture. For instance, *"Maximize your productivity…maximize all of the success"* (Tam Kaur, 2023); *"Mindset is everything,.. then the very first step is to change your mindset and the identity that you've created for yourself…switch that mindset around"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024). From the lens of Hofstede's dimensions, this reflects individualistic values since the self is regarded as an autonomous, self-improving agent.

Finally, at the syntactical level, American vloggers employ rhetorical questions mainly so as to engage the audience in reflection, e.g. *"…what is even the point in working so hard if you don't have time to be fully present with the people who matter most?"* (Dr Faye Bate, 2025). American vloggers have been found to utilise several more syntactic structures such as inversion structures, which appear to be used to highlight personal revelations and emphasise the abnormality of choices reflecting a deviation from conventional career expectations, e.g. *"Not only have I built my creative side hustle, I have a fuller life now, and I'm so grateful that I was brave enough to make this decision"* (Hippy Highland Living, 2022); *"Not only does it feel good, but studies show that meaningful social interactions can reduce stress hormones and boost oxytocin, also known as the love hormone"* (Dr Faye Bate, 2025). Another imperative stylistic device that is vivid is antithesis. American vlogs provide examples where the device is utilised as a tool for increasing motivation, e.g. *"So consider this the last day of your lazy lifestyle and the first of your success story"* (Tam Kaur, 2023). In this context, the syntactic device expresses the orientation towards masculine values and short-term motivation as the emphasis is not on the process, but on the moment of transformation and immediate results. One more peculiar device is syntactic parallelism that is present in both American and Russian videos. Regarding American vlogs, content creators most often apply parallelism to personal narratives that display behavioral patterns and inner transformation, e.g. *"I'm walking downstairs to get a cup of water, I'm holding my phone; I go into the bathroom, I'm bringing my phone; go to*

make food, I'm bringing my phone"(Sophie DiLoreto, 2024). This device allows the author in this example to question unconscious patterns of behavior (e.g., using a cell phone unnecessarily) and motivate a conscious change, which is rather consistent with a high degree of individualism and short-term orientation. What that means is that the person is responsible for their own performance and needs to reassess his or her current patterns. Moreover, syntactic parallelism is utilised in order to express opposing options as equivalent, for instance, *"Maybe you really enjoy living a fast-paced or eccentric life, and there's nothing wrong with that, but there's also nothing wrong with not wanting that"* (Malama Life, 2021). What is emphasised here is a sense of acceptance and variation in choice, which is characteristic of a more feminine culture where diversity and well-being are valued, not just the outcome. It should be also pointed out that syntactic parallelism is employed in order to motivate people to change their lifestyle, and to keep them engaged until the end of the video, e.g. *"I can promise you, by the end of this video, you'll know exactly how to stop procrastinating, how to stop being lazy, break free from your phone addiction (with some unique tips), how to create a simple plan to stay organized, and how to overcome perfectionism so that you can actually start making real progress in your life"* (fayefilms, 2024). Besides, cleft sentences are frequently used by American vloggers to point out the source of personal fulfillment or dissatisfaction, e.g. *"More importantly, this ordinary, boring life is what fulfills me"* (Malama Life, 2021); *"Because that means every day you wake up, you're dreading the day ahead. And that dread is what leads to procrastination"* (Tam Kaur, 2023); *"Building good habits is so important for staying productive and motivated because that is what keeps you going, and especially when you're super busy, you'll really appreciate having good habits in place so you don't really have to think about doing the right thing"* (LenaLifs, 2024). This syntactic emphasis reflects a cultural orientation toward introspection and emotional well-being, revealing an underlying critique of traditional hustle culture from a more feminine and long-term perspective. These examples demonstrate a cultural orientation that deviates from Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory, which stresses self-reflection and emotional wellbeing,

revealing an implicit critique of the conventional idea of hustle culture from a more feminine perspective.

Discursive Practice Level

American vlogs show a strong alignment with the wellness/self-help genre and draw heavily on popular productivity literature and motivational media. Frequent intertextual references to mainstream self-help authors, e.g., James Clear's *Atomic Habits*, social media influencers, and wellness platforms underscore how ideas about self-improvement and working hard are closely connected to the business of online content. For instance, the following statements point out how productivity narratives are spread through the media people tend to consume every day: *"I actually took this from the book Atomic Habits by James Clear. Highly, highly recommend—especially if you struggle with organizing and getting things done like me"* (LenaLifts, 2024), *"This reminds me of the principle from the book Atomic Habits where he says to make the bad habit difficult"* (Sophie DiLoreto, 2024), *"I go on TikTok, and I'll type in motivational content, motivational speeches"* (Tam Kaur, 2023), *I actually got it from this law student TikToker that I follow* (LenaLifts, 2024), *"You can also listen to motivational podcasts (I love these ones) or look at a Pinterest board with your goals or your favorite quotes"* (Leyla Tavas, 2023).

Another core discursive feature in American vlogs is the commercialisation of self-optimisation and productivity. A significant number of American vloggers recommend or promote services and products that promise to increase productivity, from fitness supplements and apps to online platforms. These recommendations are usually seamlessly woven into the narrative as personal recommendations, blurring the line between genuine experience and sponsored advertising. For example, *"HelloFresh has truly made my life 10 times easier. As a busy girl with so many tasks and work to juggle,... maximize all of the success I have in my working life because mealtime is just done"* (Tam Kaur, 2023) or *"I use Notion to do all of that in one—to organize my life, plan my videos, make my daily to-do list. And how I know Notion works for me is because every time I've fallen off with using it, my productivity level is just completely tanked"* (mikayla mags, 2025).

Reflections related to the pandemic are also featured prominently, showing how the socio-political context shaped personal attitudes towards work, slowness, and reassessment of life goals, e.g. *"I idolized being busy and gave up any sort of hobbies – my life was my work. Then a lockdown happened"* (Hippy Highland Living, 2022); *During the pandemic, we saw more slow YouTube channels and blogs pop up. Why? Because we had to take it easy thanks to government lockdowns and home quarantines* (A Slow Simple Life, 2023).

In addition, a tendency to combine different genres has been found in American vlogs, namely the genres of tutorials, confessions, motivational speeches, and diaries, which results in a mixed discourse. For instance, *"Even if I feel better when I'm productive, sometimes rest is needed. I fall into a rut at times too, and that is completely okay. Every human needs time to relax, to rewind, and to charge—just like your phone. It needs to charge in order to keep running and to keep providing"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024). In this example, Helaine Zhao combines several genres in the vlog, namely confession and tutorial.

Social Practice Level

At the level of social practice, American content creators construct hustle culture as a lifestyle choice that combines discipline and aesthetic self-care. Productivity is seen not simply as a functional goal, but as a representation of identity, especially within a feminine aesthetic: *"…so that I can be productive but also live my <u>soft girl life</u>, which is extremely important"* (Tam Kaur, 2023), *"My <u>beautiful</u> pre-workout cocktail—<u>in a wine glass</u>, of course. Cheers! Fire"* (LenaLifts, 2024), "*What I love most about this planner is that I can make <u>cute little spreads</u> on it"* (mikayla mags, 2025).

These examples highlight how in American culture, and more specifically in American vlogs, visualised productivity (complete with planners, vision boards, and curated routines) is represented as both individual self-actualisation and public display, especially on platforms such as YouTube. This aestheticised approach is in line with the feminine code of productivity, where "softness" and "productivity" blend well and complement each other.

At the same time, these vlogs emphasise personal achievement, self-control, and discipline as core values: *"Discipline is about mastering self-control, and the way you do that is you start practicing setting boundaries with yourself—saying no to yourself, taking control of your life"* (Tam Kaur, 2023), *"But motivation can't keep you going forever, so discipline is where it's really at"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024). It is also worth noting the frequent reference to James Clear among American vloggers, many of them repeatedly mention his quote, but do not name the author himself, e.g. *"So I want you guys to remember this quote, okay? "The cost of procrastination is the life that you could have lived"* (LenaLifts, 2024); *"A quote that I heard, and I've not been able to get out of my head since, is: "The cost of procrastination is the life you could have lived"* (Sophie DiLoreto, 2024). In this quote, time is regarded as a finite resource that needs to be invested wisely and lost time is equated with lost opportunities, which is in line with the capitalist ideology that turns human behaviour and productivity into a commodity.

This reflects the notion that each individual is responsible for their own success, and that being able to manage their time and be disciplined is considered mandatory to achieve anything in life. Furthermore, a high achievement orientation is vivid here (Masculinity), equating performance with self-esteem and success.

To conclude, the analysis of American vlogs fully confirms the high rate of individualism (60 points) in American culture, according to Hofstede (Country Comparison Tool, 2023). The dominance of the pronouns *"I"* and *"you"*, the emphasis on personal responsibility and personal choice reflect the value of personal autonomy characteristic of American society. The use of imperatives in the form of direct instructions, which presupposes independent decision-making by the addressee, is especially indicative.

Furthermore, it is worth noting that the high indicator of masculinity (62 points) is also vividly reflected in the content. The analysis reveals the predominance of terms related to achievements. The metaphors of mechanisation and competitive attitudes demonstrate a typically masculine orientation towards results, competition and success. However, it is worth noting a certain contradiction: despite the general masculine orientation, feminine elements can be traced in the aestheticisation of productivity

(*"soft girl life"*), which may indicate the evolution of gender stereotypes in the modern digital space.

As for long-term orientation, the most remarkable divergence from Hofstede's theory is detected here. While the official figures suggest a lack of clear orientation (50 points), the analysis of the vlogs reveals a pronounced short-term perspective. The emphasis on instant actions and results indicate a desire for immediate effect. Even the concept of "routine", traditionally associated with long-term planning, is presented through immediate benefits, consistent with American culture's tendency toward short-term orientation. At the discursive practice level, short-term orientation can be seen in the emphasis on "life hacks", which is vivid in the promotion of products, e.g. *"HelloFresh has truly made my life 10 times easier"* (Tam Kaur, 2023).

However, the study revealed two significant aspects that do not fully fit the theory. To start with, the paradox of emotionality, which means that despite masculinity, a strong affective component is noted, which is traditionally considered a feminine characteristic. This can be explained by the commodification of emotions in self-help discourse, where feelings become a tool for productivity. A hybridity of temporal perspective is also evident, namely along with the dominance of short-term strategies, a narrative of long-term "discipline" is evident, making unambiguous categorisation complicated.

The deviations might be explained by the specificity of digital content, which reinforces certain cultural trends, also by the evolution of traditional values under the influence of the wellness movement, and by the commercialisation of the self-help industry, which creates new discursive hybrids.

Russian Vlogs

Text Level

According to Table C2 (see Appendix C), at the morphemic level, the use of modal constructions with social and normative colouring becomes a key feature of Russian vlogs. The frequent use of the words *"нужно"* (87) and *"должен"* (25) and negated constructions such as *"не надо"* (5) forms a discourse of external obligation, where productivity appears as a social norm rather than a personal choice. These

formulations often reflect an external necessity or a communal expectation rather than an individual decision, which might indicate a collectivist orientation. For example, *“Ваш мозг должен иметь конкретный алгоритм: что и когда ему делать и ради чего”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024) presents discipline as something imposed from the outside, which corresponds to the collectivist orientation of Russian culture according to Hofstede.

Besides, it cannot but be mentioned that imperative constructions in Russian vlogs are softened through the form of advice. Phrases such as *“Хвалите себя за маленькие победы”* (Alina Marketing, 2024), *“Старайтесь грамотно распределять свою нагрузку”* (AlexGoldenGirl, 2024), *“Мой вам совет: приводите себя в порядок как можно скорее после того, как проснулись, и не оттягивайте это до последнего”* (Anya Ru, 2022) carry a friendly recommendation rather than an orderly character, reflecting more “feminine” values of caring and mutual support.

What is more, it is notable that Russian content creators mostly stick to inclusive pronouns like *“мы”,* e.g. “Многие вещи, которые мы выполняем ежедневно, уже становятся автоматическими, и порой мы забываем, к чему именно хотим прийти” (Kristina Laktionova, 2022), and collective encouragements “Давайте коллективно поделимся своими успехами и неудачами под роликом”(Alina Marketing, 2024), which implies a collectivist society where mutual support and sharing of experiences is paramount.

Moreover, Russian vloggers often reflect on personal failures and daily struggles, creating a more realistic and less idealised view of productivity, e.g. *“Мне достаточно сложно встать с кровати сразу после будильника, думаю, как большинству из вас”* (mitiny, 2024a). This is consistent with Hofstede’s description of Russian culture as lower in individualism and higher in long-term orientation, where delayed gratification and collective values are more culturally embedded.

Lexical analysis reveals the prioritisation of notions of stability and gradual growth over instantaneous results (see Table 6).

Table 6

The most frequent nouns utilised to describe hustle culture in Russian vlogs

Nouns	Frequency
время	129
привычка	49
дисциплина	39
рутина	32
чувство	26
действие	24
цель	14
достижение	13

The frequent use of *“время”* and *“дисциплина”* illustrates self-control and fulfilment of obligations, which may indicate low individualism and an uncharacteristic tendency towards masculinity in Russian culture. *“Привычки”and “рутина”* stress repetition and order rather than inspiration, this denotes that productivity is seen as the result of daily work, which correlates with long term orientation. It cannot but be mentioned that *“чувство”* is often found in the context of self-care, which corresponds with a feminine culture dominated by caring. Regarding *“действие”*, *“цель”*, and *“достижение”*, they might indicate a result-orientation and the idea of an effective life, which reflects elements masculine culture as well as the aspect of short-term orientation, which underscores immediate action and specific goals.

So as to describe hustle culture and the attitude towards it, Russian vloggers mostly employ adjectives which possess positive evaluation (see Table 7).

Table 7

The most frequent adjectives utilised to describe hustle culture in Russian vlogs

Russian adjectives	Frequency

продуктивный	62
полезный	32
здоровый	20
идеальный	14
дисциплинированный	9

Russian content creators predominantly utilise adjectives *“продуктивный”*, *“полезный”*, *“здоровый”*, and *“дисциплинированный”*. It is also pivotal to mention the word *“идеальный”*, which focuses on high standards and perfectionism, as well as in American discourse.

Regarding the most frequent verbs associated with hustle culture (see Table 8) Russian content creators often use verbs related to emotion (*“feel”, “чувствовать”*) and activity (*“work”, “работать”*), which highlight experiencing hustle culture as an emotionally intense process that requires effort.

Table 8

The most frequent verbs utilised to describe hustle culture in Russian vlogs

Russian verbs	Frequency
работать	54
чувствовать	43
изменить	27
контролировать	11
развиваться	10

Russian vlogs often employ the verbs *“контролировать”* and *“развиваться”*, which could point out a focus on self-regulation, discipline, and self-improvement. The idea of sustainable development within rules and norms, characteristic of collectivist

and more structurally oriented societies, is observable. Besides, it is notable that the verb *"изменить"* also features prominently, which is associated with getting out of a *"lazy"* state rather than with the search for an ideal version of oneself.

At the lexical level, Russian vloggers rely on metaphors grounded in emotional and social cognition, often employing figurative language to highlight self-awareness and long-term growth. For example, discomfort is framed not as an obstacle (as in many American vlogs) but as an ally: *"...воспринимать его не как врага, а как союзника"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). The juxtaposition of "враг" and "союзник" puts the individual not in conflict with the inner state, but in dialogue with it, which leads to self-awareness and acceptance. In addition, the recurring metaphor of a journey, for instance, the comparison of personal growth to steering a bicycle already in motion, emphasises movement, continuity, and self-direction: *"На самом деле всегда всё только в ваших руках, и решение стать лучшей версией себя – я считаю, что это лучшее проявление любви к себе. Всё это можно сравнить с катанием на велосипеде: гораздо легче поменять направление и, так скажем, крутануть руль, когда ты уже крутишь педали, а не когда ты только думаешь о том, как ты будешь крутить педали"* (AlexGoldenGirl, 2025). Meanwhile, the metaphor "...*путь лени — это путь сожаления"* (Alina Marketing, 2024) presents laziness as a path leading to a specific and emotionally negative outcome – regret. (Alina Marketing, 2024). Another vivid metaphor is "*ведро с крабами* " (the crab bucket), where others prevent one's escape (Kristina Laktionova, 2024), which brings attention to collective dynamics, illustrating how group environments can hinder or support individual progress. One more example that is to be mentioned is *"...просто находимся в своей, так скажем, зоне. И на самом деле это не совсем правильно – это просто нужно суметь перебороть"* (AlexGoldenGirl, 2025). This metaphor depicts a metaphorical "zone" of comfort and inactivity. It suggests that although being in this zone is pleasant, it hinders progress and must be overcome. The metaphor illustrates the internal tension between comfort and progress, reflecting an internal dialogue rather than an external struggle, indicative of collectivism and feminine values. The author implies that the solution is not to "maximise" but to gradually break down inertia. Last but not least,

Russian vloggers value the notion of "routine" and regard it as safe, e.g. *"Рутина и режим – это не только про ваши цели и привычки. Это прежде всего про безопасность, про стабильность"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). Overall, these metaphorical constructions tend to foreground Long-Term Orientation and a Collectivist sensibility, emphasising not immediate results but the integrity of the process, emotional resilience, and gradual self-improvement within social ecosystems.

One more vivid linguistic means in Russian vlogs is personification.Vloggers often personify internal psychological states: "*Негативные мысли могут сильно тормозить и не давать продвигаться вперёд"* (Marie Kory, 2025). One more peculiar example is the following: *"Цель должна вдохновлять, вызывать тот самый трепет, а привычки должны вызывать дискомфорт"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). This quote shows a double personification: the goal and habits are endowed with the ability to evoke feelings – inspiration, awe, and discomfort. Such emotional states are usually associated with interpersonal relationships, but here they are tied to abstract notions that act as subjects of influence.

Among the devices it is also worth mentioning repetition, which is used by Russian vloggers utilise in order to show struggle, underline emotional tension, and normalise internal conflict as part of the hustle process: *"Вы чаще всего сдаётесь, вы чаще всего не выполняете свои обещания, не выполняете свою рутину…"* (Alina Tereshko, 2024). The repeated negation *"не выполняете"* creates an atmosphere of emotional exhaustion and anticipated guilt as the viewer realises their moral deviation from the norm. Next repeated term is *"навык"* (skill), e.g. *"Навык организовывать своё время, навык создания рутины, навык преодолевать трудности…"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). It reveals a cultural framing of productivity as something that must be acquired through laborious effort, not assumed as innate.

At the syntactical level, Russian content creators utilise rhetorical questions mainly so as to engage the audience in reflection and to serve a more motivational and corrective purpose. It might be suggested that they are used to make the viewer think about themselves and their actions, emphasising that they deserve the best and should strive for it. , e.g. *"Разве ты этого заслужила? Нет. Ведь ты заслуживаешь всего*

самого лучшего…Разве ты хочешь, чтобы в твоей истории ты была вечно грустным и страдающим персонажем? Думаю, что нет” (Alina Marketing, 2024); *“Сколько раз вы писали список дел на день и сколько раз он потерпел неудачу?”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2022). Furthermore, it is worth mentioning that rhetorical questions in Russian vlogs Next, Russian vlogs also actively incorporate antithesis, which is done in the form of instructive advice or moralising, for instance, “*Дисциплина – это одна из высших форм проявления уважения к себе. А лень способна привести только к одному – сожалению*” ; “*Система - это ежедневные действия, это привычки. Цель - это конечный результат. Цель должна вдохновлять, вызывать тот самый трепет, а привычки должны вызывать дискомфорт*” (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). These examples are consistent with a collectivist and long-term oriented culture that values continuous self-improvement through habits, effort, and the “right” system of behavior rather than instant success. Moreover, syntactic parallelism is employed to reinforce the “correct” thought pattern, e.g. *“Когда идёте учиться через “не хочу”, когда собираетесь на тренировку сквозь “миллиарды я не могу””* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). It can be assumed that the repetitive constructions reinforce the heroism of everyday coping, which expresses a masculine orientation towards struggle, effort and discipline. In other cases, parallelism is used to validate feelings, for example, “*Нужно давать своим эмоциям место: хочешь плакать — поплачь, злишься — позлись, устала — отдохни*” (Alina Marketing, 2024), which demonstrates a feminine shift within the Russian understanding of self-discipline (emotional flexibility becomes part of productivity).

Discursive Practice Level

Russian content creators draw on self-help literature, e.g., James Clear: *“Меня очень вдохновила книга Джеймса Клира “Атомные привычки”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024). However, the discourse is more introspective, Russian vloggers often express feelings, psychological difficulties, and personal development. There is a sense of reflection and a desire to make sense of the issues in their speech, and they talk openly about trauma, burnout and inner obstacles. Statements such as *“Тебя травмировали, и ты не справляешься? Самое время обратиться к психологу”*

(Alina Marketing, 2024), *“Бумага — это самый быстрый и экстренный терапевт”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024), or *“Если вы чувствуете, что у вас есть "болезни души", то лучше сразу идти к нужному врачу — ведь работа не уберет депрессию, а под ленью может скрываться апатия”*(Фая, 2023) indicate a deeper integration of psychological discourse into vloggers’ ruminations on self-discipline.

A recurring theme is self-diagnosis and self-regulation as key components of productivity. Emotional states (fear, anxiety, laziness) are seen not only as obstacles to success, but also as symptoms that need to be dealt with, often with the help of therapy or spiritual practices, e.g. *“Исследования подтверждают, что книги для саморазвития могут избавить читателя от депрессивного настроя и изменить укоренившийся образ мышления”* (Фая, 2023), *“Также, когда я встаю рано, больше времени могу уделить себе: различным практикам, которые наполняют меня энергией на весь день”* (Marie Kory, 2024).

Russian vlogs also show the influence of social media on the formation of self-perception, motivation, and self-organisation of speakers, for instance, *“Итак, ты хочешь стать идеальной студенткой – той девушкой из Pinterest, которая всегда без особых усилий проходит обучение и получает пятёрки”* (Julia Avis, 2024), *“Меня вдохновляют фильмы, книги и видео на YouTube…Pinterest я использую, если нужно придумать что-то интересное – он даёт вдохновение на новые идеи”* (Marie Kory, 2025). These examples illustrate how youth bloggers rely on aesthetic patterns from Pinterest, YouTube, and other platforms, borrow visual and speech formats and embed them in their behaviour.

Despite less overt product placement, Russian vloggers also mention tools and products, but these typically emphasise emotional authenticity and peer-like relationships, e.g. *“Пользуясь таким невероятным случаем, хочу поделиться с вами своей находкой за последний месяц - а именно сервисом “О смысле”. “О смысле” – это образовательная платформа с огромным перечнем различных лекций: от психологии до маркетинга, развития блога и soft skills”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2022) or *“И, господи, я вам отдаю от чистого сердца свою находку – это YouTube-канал Русский язык с Нелли”* (sosomak, 2023).

Social Practice Level

In Russian vlogs, hustle culture is portrayed through the prism of external pressures. In this context, productivity is considered not as a lifestyle, but rather as a forced measure and a necessity for survival and competition: *"Так что запоминаем как мантру: пока ты плачешь, кто-то дисциплинированно работает"; "Если ты не найдёшь в себе силы ответить на приглашение, то упустишь свой шанс, и твоё место займёт кто-то другой"* (Alina Marketing, 2024); *"...Меня окружает очень много трудолюбивых людей. И у них у всех есть одна черта - они никогда, никогда не жаловались"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024).

These statements create a harsh environment in which emotional softness is a hindrance, indicative of the culture's tendency towards Masculinity. The implication is that the vlogger's success is not related to personal pleasure, but to his ability to tolerate, persevere, and suppress weakness. This also reflects Russian collectivist society, where productivity is seen as a moral obligation, often enforced by social comparison and the threat that one is easily replaceable.

However, there is also a parallel discourse that mitigates this rigidity through an aestheticised, feminine environment, as in American vlogs, e.g. *"Собери доску на Pinterest с эстетичными картинками, связанными с дисциплиной"* (Alina Marketing, 2024), *"Последний, одиннадцатый совет — это создать себе благоприятную атмосферу для учёбы"* (AlexGoldenGirl, 2024), *"Эти ограничения — это мужская история. Это вот не про любовь к себе, не про расслабление, не про кайф, не про поток"* (Алина Терешко, 2024).

In addition, it is pivotal to point out that Russian vlogs stress an increasing emphasis on mindset change and emotional self-management as focal components of success. Vloggers tend to encourage viewers to restructure their mindset by switching from external obligations to voluntary ones: *"Вместо "я должен", "мне нужно это сделать" попробуйте говорить себе: "я выбираю" или "я хочу""* (Kristina Laktionova, 2022). This linguistic peculiarity illustrates a deeper ideological shift towards psychological responsibility for one's actions. Moreover, the motivational discourse in Russian vlogs treats procrastination and failure not as something

unchangeable, but as something that can be challenged and replaced with empowering alternatives. For instance, *“я провалюсь”* can be replaced with *“я сделаю всё возможное”* (Marie Kory, 2025) puts the emphasis on internal effort and emotional resilience rather than external outcomes. This approach shows that in Russian modern society people are increasingly expected to manage themselves, namely to control their emotions, behaviour and habits as if they were running their own business. At the same time, one can notice a duality: on the one hand, the idea of constant employment and productivity remains the main idea, but on the other hand, people try to reduce its psychological pressure with the help of the right words, cosy environment, and emotional support.

All things considered, the analysis of Russian vlogs demonstrates a complex picture with elements of both conformity and partial divergence from the theory. To start with, vlogs strongly supports Hofstede’s cultural dimensions theory, where individualism is remarkably low (46 points), indicating a collectivist society (Country Comparison Tool, 2023). Next, the frequent usage of such a pronoun as *“мы”*, and emphasis on common difficulties reflect the collectivist orientation typical of Russian culture. Especially indicative is the use of modal constructions *“нужно”* and *“должен”*, which represent productivity as a social norm rather than a personal choice. Collectivism manifests itself through social pressure, which reflects the prioritisation of group standards over individual desires.

According to Hofstede, Russian culture can be classified as feminine with a score of 36 on the masculinity dimension. The linguistic features of the content clearly show features of feminine culture, especially in the use of softened imperatives, which are presented not as harsh commands but as friendly advice. The frequent use of adjectives with an obvious feminine colouring, e.g. *“полезный”* and *“здоровый”*, which link productivity not so much with achievements as with well-being, is particularly revealing, which fully corresponds to the parameters of feminine culture according to Hofstede. However, there is a discrepancy between the theory according to Hofstede and the vlogs. The discourse of Russian vlogs contains pronounced masculine elements that create a certain tension with the theory. First of all, this is manifested in the lexical

choice, namely words *“дисциплина”*, *“работать”* or *“контролировать”* occur much more frequently than in typically feminine cultures, and metaphors of struggle and leaving one's comfort zone reflect a rather masculine orientation towards achievement and competition. It should be stressed that even the concept of “самодисциплина” is presented through harsh language, which is typical of masculine cultures. Despite the presence of some masculine elements, which might be explained by the specificity of the hustle culture genre itself, these concepts are mitigated through a feminine discourse of care, imperatives are presented as advice rather than orders, and there is an emphasis on emotion and reflection. Even the notion of discipline is often associated with self-care rather than external achievement, which is particularly evident in constructions such as *“рутина и режим это про безопасность”* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024).

The analysis of Russian vlogs in the context of long-term orientation (58 points) demonstrates full compliance with the theoretical parameters, with a number of peculiarities. Lexical analysis reveals a systemic emphasis on processes rather than outcomes, for example, the noun *“привычка”* (49) occurs three times more frequently than *“достижение”* (13), and the verb *“развиваться”* (10) prevails over *“оптимизировать”* (the latter is virtually absent). This reflects the fundamental attitude to gradual improvement characteristic of cultures with a high long-term orientation. The reinterpretation of of “routine” is particularly revealing. It is stated that “*Рутина и режим - это не только про ваши цели и привычки. Это прежде всего про безопасность, про стабильность*” (Kristina Laktionova, 2024), which emphasises its function as a long-term support. Metaphors in Russian vlogs also invariably reflect a long-term perspective. It is peculiar that the images of the path and gradual movement and development prevail, where the emphasis is on the process rather than the point of arrival. At the level of discursive practice, long-term orientation is manifested in the integration of educational platforms (e.g. “О смысле”). Regarding the social practice level, it is seen in the rethinking of productivity as a lifelong skill (*“я выбираю”* вместо *“я должен”*), with a focus shifting from external coercion to internal transformation.

Comparative Analysis of American and Russian Vlogs

The comparison of Russian and American vlogs through a Critical Discourse Analysis (CDA) framework and Cross-Cultural Analysis reveals both similarities and differences in how linguistic choices reflect broader societal values.

Text Level

The analysis of morphemic level reveals that both American and Russian vloggers frequently utilise modal verbs. As for American vlogs, they feature modals and quasi-modals (Collins, 2009) such as *"can"* (217), *"would"* (55), *"could"* (46), *"might"* (41), *"should"* (24), *"have to"* (74), and *"need to"* (49), creating a discourse imbued with obligation, urgency, and personal responsibility. In contrast, Russian vlogs exhibit a different tone in their use. Vloggers utilise modal verbs like *"должен"* (25), *"нужно"* (87), and negated constructions such as "не надо" (5) which convey a more normative and socially framed sense of obligation in Russian culture. These formulations often reflect an external necessity or a communal expectation rather than an individual decision, which might indicate a collectivist orientation.

Another linguistic device often detected in both cultures is imperative verbs. While in American vlogs the frequent use of imperatives reinforces a sense of self-discipline and efficiency, which is consistent with Hofstede's characterisation of American culture as highly individualistic and masculine, i.e. people are expected to be confident, success-oriented and competitive, Russian content creators tend to soften imperatives with context and frame them as advice or encouragement rather than commands, resulting in a more caring and feminine approach.

In addition, the usage of personal pronouns also differs across the cultures. In American-language content, the personal pronouns *"you"* and *"I"* are utilised so as to stress personal choice and responsibility, implying that each individual determines his or her own success or failure. By contrast, Russian vlogs show a stronger tendency toward inclusive pronouns, namely *"мы",* therefore, creating the effect of a shared path to productivity, which helps to erase the boundaries between vlogger and viewer, forming an imaginary community of like-minded people. This is in line with the

collectivist attitude of Russian culture, where individual achievements are often understood through the prism of group affiliation.

At the textual level within Fairclough's critical discourse analysis, lexical choice plays a pivotal role in how hustle culture is linguistically constructed and ideologically framed. The findings of the study demonstrate both similarities and differences in what American and Russian vloggers associate hustle culture with. In American content, the nouns *"time"* (141), *"work"*(87), *"productivity"*(58) and *"goal"* (54) are more frequently used, reflecting an orientation towards efficient use of time, achievement of goals and personal productivity. These lexical preferences correspond to the values of individualism and masculinity, where success is measured by concrete results and personal achievements. On the contrary, in Russian-language vlogs, the words *"время"* (129), *"дисциплина"* (39), *"привычка"* (49) and *"рутина"* (32) are more common, emphasising the importance of systematic work and self-control. As a result, the lexical choice sticks to a long-term orientation in the perception of productivity due to the fact that the emphasis is on process rather than instant results. It is noteworthy that both the noun *"чувство"* in Russian vlogs and the noun *"feeling"* in American vlogs are used in the context of self-care, which might lead to a more balanced approach to the topic of productivity.

Concerning the description of the attitude towards hustle culture, the majority of American and Russian vloggers have a tendency to implement similar adjectives. Overall, the adjectives tend to carry a positive evaluation, contributing to the desire of becoming like the person being described. The content creators use them to praise the idea behind the phenomenon of hustle culture and what it stands for. However, it is pivotal to underscore the main differences that manifest themselves in the evaluation and connotation, namely American adjectives (*"perfect", "happy"*) reflect the cult of the ideal result and positive emotions as indicators of success, while Russian ones (*"полезный", "здоровый"*) emphasise practical value and balance. This corresponds to general cultural trends, that the American emphasis on individual achievements versus the Russian focus on usefulness and sustainability. At the same time, both discourses

retain a common core (*“productive”/ “протворенный”*), but fill it with different cultural content.

Comparing the frequency of verbs in American and Russian vlogs we can find both similarities and differences in the representation of productivity. Both American and Russian content creators often use verbs related to emotion and activity (*“feel”/”чувствовать”, “work”/”работать”*), which highlight the generalised nature of experiencing hustle culture as an emotionally intense process that requires effort. However, some differences also were detected while analysing other verbs. First and foremost, American content creators tend to focus on inner transformation and effectiveness, using verbs such as *“change”* and *“optimize”*. What that means is that American vloggers emphasise personal growth and changing oneself for the better, which presumably implies a high degree of individualism and masculinity in the culture. On the contrary, Russian vlogs more often employ the verbs *“контролировать”* and *“развиваться”*, which could point out a focus on self-regulation, discipline, and self-improvement. Unlike *“optimize”*, the idea of sustainable development within rules and norms, characteristic of collectivist and more structurally oriented societies, is observable. Besides, it is notable that the verb *“изменить”* appears to be significant, but in the Russian context it is often associated with getting out of a “lazy” state rather than with the search for an ideal version of oneself.

Metaphorical constructions in American and Russian vlogs demonstrate fundamentally different approaches to the notion of “productivity”. The American content is characterised by predominant metaphors of mechanisation, representing the human being as a mechanism that requires optimization: *“work machine”*, *“brain dump”*, *“mental load”*. These images reflect an orientation towards maximum efficiency, where even rest (*“diamonds are made under pressure”* (Anna Neubert, 2025)) is seen as a tool for increasing productivity. It is notable that laziness is metaphorically portrayed as a technical malfunction (*“get out of the lazy rut”* (Leyla Tavas, 2023) that needs to be urgently eliminated. Russian vloggers use a fundamentally different system of images based on existential and social metaphors. The key notion is the path (“*путь лени — это путь сожаления”* (Alina Marketing,

2024)), where productivity is conceptualised as a long-term movement rather than an instant result. The redefinition of discomfort is particularly revealing: while in American vlogs it is an *"enemy"*, in Russian vlogs it tends to be an "ally" with whom a dialogue must be built. The metaphor of the "ведро с крабами" emphasises the importance of the social context, which is absent in the individualistic American discourse. A striking contrast is observed in the interpretation of routine. American authors present it as a tool for quick results, while Russian authors present it as a basis for stability (*"Рутина и режим – это про безопасность, про стабильность"* (Kristina Laktionova, 2024)).

Another linguistic means that is considered in the research is personification. The research reveals fundamental differences in the ways that American and Russian vloggers personify the notion of "productivity". In American vlogs, hustle culture is presented as an external force that requires submission and sacrifice. The image of *"life you want"* (LenaLifts, 2024) is presented as something that can be achieved only through constant work on oneself, creating a sense of external pressure and the need to meet high standards. Russian vloggers take a completely different approach, personifying internal psychological states. In their discourse, abstract notions like *"goals"* and *"habits"* are endowed with the ability to influence a person's emotional state. It is noteworthy that even *"discomfort"* from new habits is presented as a necessary element of growth rather than an obstacle.

Moreover, some repetitions were detected in both American and Russian videos. In American-language content, the repetition of focal words such as *"productivity"*, *"maximisation"*, *"mindset"* serves as a tool to affirm a successful lifestyle, creating an attitude of continuous self-improvement. This approach reflects individualistic values, where the individual is perceived as an independent agent of change. On the contrary, in Russian vlogs, repetitions fulfil a different function, which is the emphasis on the complexity of the path to productivity. For instance, the frequent use of the word *"навык"*, which highlights the need for gradual mastery of productivity practices through hard work.

It is also worth noting that special attention is paid to the notion of "discipline" by both American and Russian content creators. For instance, American vloggers tend not to rely merely on motivation, but also on discipline since *"it is sustainable long-term"*, e.g. "*I focus on discipline. And everyone wants to know, How can you become more disciplined? Discipline is about mastering self-control, and the way you do that is you start practicing setting boundaries with yourself—saying no to yourself, taking control of your life"* (Tam Kaur, 2023); *"But motivation can't keep you going forever, so discipline is where it's really at"* (Helaine Zhao, 2024). Although American culture is traditionally seen as a culture that seeks quick results, the vlogs demonstrate the tendency of American content creators to shift towards long-lasting, gradual changes in themselves by sticking to discipline. Russian vloggers also underscore the significance of the notion of "discipline" and "self-discipline": *"Когда ты становишься дисциплинированным человеком, ты понимаешь, что масштабные и самые заветные мечты достигаются путём долгой и последовательной работы. Это достигается путём усилий и терпения. Именно поэтому развивать самодисциплину очень важно"*(Marie Kory, 2025). Moreover, it is stressed that discipline is a blessing: *"Дисциплина - это одна из высших форм проявления уважения к себе"*(Kristina Laktionova, 2024). Hence, it can be assumed that control, effort, and strictness is seen as a virtue, while gentleness and giving in is a weakness, which demonstrates high masculinity. It is also worth emphasising that discipline is seen as a discomfort to help heal from the addiction to comfort, namely laziness: *"Лень — это твоя привычка находиться в комфорте. Ты зависима от комфорта. А дисциплина — это зависимость от дискомфорта"* (Alina Marketing, 2024).

At the syntactical level, there are both similarities and differences in the use of stylistic techniques between American and Russian vloggers. Rhetorical questions in both cases serve to engage the audience, but in Russian vlogs, they are often motivational and expository in nature. What is more, American content creators extensively use inversion constructions and cleft sentences to point out personal revelations and deviations from traditional career paths. These techniques reflect individualistic values and a focus on personal choice. It is noteworthy that in Russian

vlogs no examples of cleft sentences were detected since there is no equivalent in the Russian language. As for antithesis in American vlogs, it tends to serve as a motivational tool in order to oppose *old* and *new* versions of oneself, which corresponds to the masculine orientation towards rapid transformation; whereas in Russian vlogs, antithesis often takes the form of enlightening statements, contrasting *"дисциплина"* and *"лень"*, *"система"* and *"цель"*. This reflects collectivist values and a long-term orientation towards gradual self-improvement. Syntactic parallelism is also used in different ways. While American content creators tend to use it to analyse personal behavioural patterns, Russian vloggers frequently employ it to assert "correct" patterns of thinking and validate emotions.

Discursive Practice Level

It is imperative to underscore that while both cultures engage in a commercialised discourse of self-improvement, American vlogs are shaped by a masculine culture where success, achievement, and productivity are key values. What is more, the vlogger might be positioned as an individual entrepreneur of the self, a person who makes the most of time and integrates tools to achieve ever higher personal goals. This corresponds to a high level of Individualism where personal autonomy and self-responsibility is dominant. The strong focus on structured systems such as goal setting, habit tracking, stresses a long-term strategic mindset, namely success is seen as the result of consistent, intentional investment in one's future, which tends to deviate from Hofstede's cultural dimensions theory, where American culture is regarded as a culture where there is no dominant preference to Short- or Long-Term Orientation.

By contrast, Russian content creators have a tendency to express a more feminine approach, where empathy, emotional openness, and psychological wellbeing are dominant. The vloggers allow viewers to explore their inner world of doubt, trauma, and reflection. Additionally, the collectivist overtones expressed through shared emotional experiences and the use of informal, intimate language indicate a decrease in individualism and a greater emphasis on relatedness and reciprocal support. While many vloggers are not as explicitly focused on long-term effectiveness, they advocate

personal development practices that support sustained mental and emotional resilience, indicating Long-Term Orientation based on psychological resilience.

Social Practice Level

At the level of social practice, vlogs by both American and Russian authors integrate hustle culture into broader cultural and societal discourses, reflecting social expectations and gender norms. While both cultures tend to endorse productivity and self-discipline, the ways in which these are articulated and justified differ significantly, reflecting their corresponding cultural contexts and ideologies.

American authors present hustle culture as a conscious lifestyle where productivity becomes part of personal branding. Visual aesthetics ("beautiful planners" and "vision boards") are combined with rigid attitudes to self-control, creating a paradoxical image of "productive gentleness". The core message is individual responsibility for success, where discipline and time management become a personal moral imperative, which corresponds to high Masculinity and Individualism. Furthermore, quotes from popular authors on self-development are used as universal mantras, emphasising the commodified nature of productivity under capitalism. Time in this discourse is presented as a limited resource, and its loss is equated with missed opportunities, reflecting the values of capitalist society, e.g. *"The cost of procrastination is the life you could have lived""* (Sophie DiLoreto, 2024).

By contrast, Russian-speaking vloggers view productivity often as a forced necessity in a competitive environment. Harsh formulations create an atmosphere of constant social pressure, where productivity becomes not so much a personal choice as a moral obligation to society. As a consequence, this reflects collectivist attitudes where comparison with others and the fear of being *"replaceable"* play an important role. Nevertheless, there is also discourse that elevates this rigidity through an aestheticised, feminine environment, as in American vlogs (*"доска на Pinterest", "благоприятная атмосфера"*). It is also worth noting that Russian vlogs are developing a counterintuitive trend, namely the *"psychologisation"* of productivity discourse. Vloggers increasingly emphasise intrinsic motivation, suggesting that obligations (*"я должен"*) should be reformulated into conscious choices ("я выбираю"). Special

attention is paid to the emotional state and the creation of a comfortable working atmosphere, which softens the initially harsh rhetoric, which might represent the feature of feminine culture.

Conclusion

This research aimed to explore and compare the linguistic and cultural representation of the hustle trend in American and Russian YouTube vlogs. Through the Critical Discourse Analysis, the study examined the linguistic representation of hustle culture in American and Russian YouTube vlogs, while the Cross-Cultural Analysis allowed to assess the cultural dimensions represented in American and Russian vlogs about hustle culture.

Primarily, the notion of hustle culture was analysed, which can be understood as a culture, as a movement or a trend, and as an ideology, or system of beliefs fostering the idea of hard work, productivity, and success. Besides, the negative impact of the hustle trend on health was considered, which highlights the importance of recognising and addressing the potential harms associated with the glorification of relentless work and the need for sustainable approaches to productivity and self-care.

Furthermore, the hustle culture discourse was derived as a socially constructed and socially constructing way of representing and communicating the values and ideologies of excessive work and constant productivity. It was further defined as argumentation, persuasive, transactional, behavioural, institutional, and dialogic discourse based on various classifications of discourse types. The core principles of the hustle culture discourse, as also identified through the analysis of American and Russian vlogs, were found to encompass entrepreneurialism or entrepreneurial qualities, psychological strategies such as life hacks, tactics, routines, and mindset, as well as digital tools that facilitate the monetization of content.

The findings of the Critical Discourse Analysis and Cross-Cultural Analysis reveal that the language employed in American and Russian YouTube vlogs discussing hustle culture is characterised by the use of modal verbs, imperative forms, personal pronouns, metaphors, personification, rhetorical questions, and antithesis. However, these linguistic features serve to construct distinct cultural representations of the hustle

phenomenon. American vlogs depict hustle culture through a predominantly masculine, individualistic, and short-term oriented framework, partially diverge from Hofstede's traditional classification of American culture. In contrast, Russian vlogs present a feminine with some inclination towards masculine, collectivist, and long-term oriented perspective on the trend, reflecting differing cultural values and interpretations.

Regarding the theoretical value, this study contributes to the existing research by critically examining the linguistic construction and cultural distinction of hustle culture. The comprehensive analytical framework for understanding the discourse surrounding hustle culture may be further developed and utilised in future discourse studies, particularly those examining digital content. This framework can facilitate deeper investigations into how multimodal elements, combining verbal, nonverbal language, visual imagery, construct and perpetuate the values, norms, and ideologies embedded in hustle culture. By extending the approach, researchers can better analyse the interplay between language, culture, and media in shaping contemporary social phenomena across diverse platforms and cultural contexts.

From a practical point of view, the research is expected to raise awareness among individuals regarding the linguistic strategies employed within hustle culture discourse, fostering critical engagement and enabling resistance to its potentially adverse influences. Furthemore, such research provides organisations, managers, and employees with a clearer understanding of how hustle culture shapes workplace expectations, behaviors, and professional relationships. Moreover, the study holds relevance for the field of intercultural communication, providing material for academic seminars and courses to illuminate the mechanisms through which cultural phenomena such as hustle culture are constructed and sustained in diverse societies.

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In accordance with *POPATKUS* guidelines, we hereby confirm that AI tools were utilised to transcribe the videos into texts, particularly **NoteGPT** and **YouTubeToTranscript**, and to place punctuation marks, specifically **ChatGPT** and **DeepSeek**.